

Tennessee - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-15 underlying quality with true freshman Faizon Brandon now named QB1; quarterback inexperience still makes Tennessee less stable than its No. 14 SP+ rating.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 20 (394 points) · SP+ No. 14
Returning production	61% (No. 29) overall · Off. 58% (No. 52) · Def. 64% (No. 17)
Primer power rating	+17.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.9 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Less proven QB experience on offense, but a credible defensive improvement path under DC Jim Knowles despite heavy turnover and injuries.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: HC Josh Heupel still has RB DeSean Bishop, WR Braylon Staley, WR Mike Matthews and an experienced OL core, with true freshman QB Faizon Brandon now named the Week 1 starter. New DC/play caller Jim Knowles is installing a flexible defense around deep linebackers and a transfer-heavy front/secondary.

Bottom line: Tennessee has top-15 ingredients, but a true-freshman starting quarterback, substantial defensive turnover and a top-20 schedule make 8-4 the sturdier preseason baseline.

Beats expectations if: QB Faizon Brandon is efficient immediately, the OL settles early, and DC Jim Knowles converts existing havoc plus transfer talent into better down-to-down defense.

Disappoints if: Brandon's inexperience creates an early efficiency drop, front/secondary turnover bites, and two season-ending defensive losses plus LB Arion Carter's opener suspension expose depth.

Five things to remember

- 1 **QB decision:** True freshman QB Faizon Brandon has been named Tennessee's Week 1 starter after winning the preseason competition.
- 2 **★ RB DeSean Bishop / WR core:** RB DeSean Bishop returns after 1,076 yards/16 TD, with WR Braylon Staley and WR Mike Matthews both back after 800-yard seasons.
- 3 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense ranked No. 8 in success rate and No. 16 in EPA/play; the defense still created havoc at a No. 20 rate.
- 4 **♦ New DC Jim Knowles:** Jim Knowles is a new external defensive coordinator and the 2026 defensive play caller; his system was still about 70% installed during camp.
- 5 **Defensive availability:** LB Arion Carter's suspension has been reduced to one game, so he will miss the Furman opener but is eligible to return at Georgia Tech; two additional defenders are out for the season.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-5 (4-4 SEC)	● Good
Scoring	39.8 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	466.3 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	173.5 YPG · 4.5 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	8.71 YPA · 26 TD / 10 INT	● Elite
Third downs	50.9%	● Elite
Scoring defense	28.8 PPG allowed	● Below average
Total defense	397.2 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	152.4 YPG · 4.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	244.8 YPG · 7.22 YPA · 19 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Tennessee paired a top-10 scoring/yardage offense with a defense that ranked No. 92 in both scoring and total defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+7.04 · No. 17	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.151 · No. 16	● Very good
Off. success rate	50.2% · No. 8	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	12.3% · No. 62	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	11.7% · No. 12	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+1.15 · No. 56	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.036 · No. 49	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	42.9% · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	13.0% · No. 100	● Below average
Havoc created	18.2% · No. 20	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: The offense was genuinely efficient (No. 8 success rate, No. 16 EPA/play) despite only average explosiveness. The defense struggled with consistency and explosives but still created havoc at a No. 20 rate.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play caller	● Josh Heupel - returning	● ↔ Offensive-system continuity remains a stabilizer through the QB change.
OC/QB	● Joey Halzle - returning	● ↔ Keeps the offensive teaching structure intact while Heupel calls plays.
DC / defensive play caller	◆ Jim Knowles - new external hire	● ↑ Credible improvement path, though the system was roughly 70% installed amid major churn.
Co-DC/Secondary	◆ Anthony Poindexter - new external hire	● ↑ Adds leadership to a heavily rebuilt secondary.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ OL Ory Williams	LSU	● ↔ LSU transfer adds a legitimate first-unit option in the best-five competition without being treated as a locked upgrade.
◆ RB Javin Gordon	Tulane	● ↔ Tulane transfer joins the major-rotation competition behind established lead back RB DeSean Bishop.

Out	To	Loss
QB Joey Aguilar	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ The 2025 starting quarterback exits; true freshman Faizon Brandon won the replacement competition.
WR Chris Brazzell II	NFL (Carolina), Round 3, No. 83	● ↓ A major 2025 receiver departs, increasing the value of WR Braylon Staley/WR Mike Matthews continuity and the open third-WR competition.
TE Miles Kitselman	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Material tight-end experience leaves, putting more of the position load on returning TE Ethan Davis.
OL Lance Heard	Kentucky	● ↓ Meaningful line turnover reduces continuity even with Moe/Sanders and other experienced candidates returning.

Offense net: High-end talent remains, but replacing the starting QB plus material WR/TE/OL pieces lowers stability. ● ↓

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Amare Campbell	Penn State	● ↑ Penn State transfer carries Bednarik/Butkus recognition and is already in a major linebacker role.
◆ DB Kayin Lee	Auburn	● ↔ Auburn transfer is in the projected starting/major secondary group, helping replace significant corner turnover.
◆ DB TJ Metcalf	Michigan	● ↔ Michigan transfer is a projected major secondary piece in the rebuild.
◆ DL Jordan Norman	Tulane	● ↔ Tulane transfer is an emerging/consistent current contributor in a front replacing several NFL departures.
◆ DL Xavier Gilliam	Penn State	● ↔ Another Penn State transfer is a major current DL option, but the overall front remains a rebuild.

Out	To	Loss
CB Colton Hood	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 2, No. 37	● ↓ Second-round corner departure is one of the largest individual losses in a reconfigured secondary.
EDGE Joshua Josephs	NFL (Washington), Round 5, No. 147	● ↓ Material edge production leaves a defensive front already undergoing major turnover.
DL Tyre West	NFL (Detroit), Round 7, No. 222	● ↓ Another front-line pro departure increases dependence on DL Jordan Norman/DL Xavier Gilliam and the rebuilt rotation.
DB Jalen McMurray	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Meaningful secondary experience exits alongside CB Colton Hood and portal losses.
EDGE/DL Chaz Coleman	Medical departure	● ↓ the later medical disqualification removes an expected 2026 front piece.

Defense net: The defense has a plausible improvement path because of Knowles, strong linebacker talent and multiple transfer additions, but front/secondary turnover plus three material availability losses prevent treating improvement as automatic. ● ↔

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Heupel-called offense built around true freshman QB Faizon Brandon, a returning 1,000-yard back, two 800-yard-class receivers and an experienced OL core.	High-end 2025 down-to-down efficiency, proven skill-position production and continuity in the offensive staff.	Brandon's first-year execution and pass protection/spacing if the best-five OL and third-receiver roles remain unsettled.
Defense	Knowles-led flexible package defense with varying linebacker counts, built around a deep LB group and a reconfigured front/secondary.	A deep linebacker group, multiple experienced transfers and a 2025 havoc-creation rate that already ranked No.20.	Replacement quality across the front and secondary, explosive-play prevention, and opener depth stress with LB Arion Carter suspended one game plus two season-ending defensive losses.
Special teams	Defined primary roles with K Cooper Ranvier on place kicks, P Jackson Ross punting/holding and defined snapping/kickoff roles.	Two recognized specialists plus clearer role definition than the offense/defense competitions.	K Cooper Ranvier is new to Tennessee, so a settled role should not be confused with settled performance quality.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	True freshman QB Faizon Brandon has won the job; high upside is paired with no college starting experience.
RB	● A–	● ↔	High	RB DeSean Bishop returns after 1,076 rushing yards and 16 touchdowns as the proven lead back.
WR	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	WR Braylon Staley and WR Mike Matthews give the new quarterback two proven high-volume targets.
TE	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Ethan Davis supplies returning experience after TE Miles Kitzelman departs.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium	OL Wendell Moe Jr. anchors an experienced core while the best five is finalized.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Heavy front turnover plus season-ending/medical losses reduce continuity around the new scheme.
LB	● A–	● ↑	Medium	LB Arion Carter returns as the tackle leader and now misses only the opener; LB Amare Campbell adds talent.
Secondary	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	A transfer-heavy rebuild retains recognized talent but must replace major secondary turnover.
Special teams	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	Roles are defined, though K Cooper Ranvier is new to Tennessee.
Coaching	● A–	● ↑	Medium	HC Josh Heupel provides offensive continuity while DC Jim Knowles adds defensive upside.
Overall	● A–	● ↔	Medium-low	Top-15 quality with strong supporting talent, but a true-freshman QB1 keeps Tennessee unusually volatile.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
George MacIntyre	QB	● High-upside reserve quarterback	-	Finished behind Faizon Brandon in the Week 1 competition and remains the most prominent reserve option.
Faizon Brandon	QB	● High-upside true-freshman starter	-	Named Week 1 starter after winning the preseason competition; his readiness is now Tennessee's largest offensive variable.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
DeSean Bishop	RB	● High-end SEC feature back	SEC Coaches/Media third team · Maxwell · Walter Camp Player of the Year	Returns after 1,076 rushing yards and 16 touchdowns and is the safest offensive workload anchor.
Braylon Staley	WR	● High-end returning Power 4 receiver	Biletnikoff	Returns 68 catches for 837 yards and six touchdowns, giving the new quarterback a proven target.
Mike Matthews	WR	● High-end returning Power 4 receiver	Biletnikoff	Returns 53 catches for 813 yards and four touchdowns and forms the other established receiving anchor.
Wendell Moe Jr.	OL	● National-level offensive-line anchor	Walter Camp 2nd · SEC Coaches/Media third team · Outland	The most decorated member of the experienced OL core and the main stabilizer while the best five is finalized.
Arion Carter	LB	● High-end SEC linebacker	SEC Coaches/Media third team · Butkus	Returns as Tennessee's SEC tackle leader and defensive centerpiece; the reduced suspension now keeps him out only for the opener.
◆ Amare Campbell (TR: Penn State)	LB	● High-end transfer linebacker	Bednarik · Butkus	Major Penn State transfer who deepens the strongest defensive position group and can help offset Carter's early absence.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Difficult: after two early tune-ups, Tennessee faces a five-game SEC block containing Texas, Alabama and South Carolina, with Texas A&M and LSU still ahead.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 20
Hardest stretch	Texas → Auburn → at Arkansas → Alabama → at South Carolina
Swing games	Texas, Alabama, at South Carolina, LSU, at Vanderbilt
Advantage	Furman and Kennesaw State provide two home evaluation windows around the early Georgia Tech trip, and the lone bye arrives after the five-game SEC block ending at South Carolina.
Expected	7.9 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	SP+ No. 14 is more bullish than AP No. 20; avoid contender pricing before the QB and defensive transitions prove out.
Back them when	The market discounts the QB transition after the winner keeps RB DeSean Bishop, WR Braylon Staley and WR Mike Matthews on schedule, or the matchup favors Tennessee's skill core and defensive disruption.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a contender premium before QB/OL stability or against offenses built to stress the rebuilt defense.
Key monitor	Faizon Brandon's early efficiency, final OL five, LB Arion Carter's Week 2 return, and front/secondary cohesion after major losses.
Week 1 baseline	vs. Furman: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Tennessee -46.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Tennessee's offense still has a strong supporting cast in RB DeSean Bishop, WR Braylon Staley, WR Mike Matthews and an experienced OL, with true freshman QB Faizon Brandon now named the starter. His lack of college starting experience keeps the ceiling unusually uncertain.

DC Jim Knowles gives the defense a credible improvement path, but turnover, two season-ending losses and LB Arion Carter's one-game suspension temper the opener. Baseline: **7.9 wins** • **likely 8-4** against SP+ SOS **No. 20**.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) • [coaching](#) • [camp / roles](#) • [scheme](#) • [departures](#) • [team source](#) • [team source 2](#) • [team source 3](#) • [QB1 update](#) • [Carter suspension update](#)

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